power gap with China, and the United States reaching out to India in its own rivalry with China – shape Indian foreign and security policy, in particular with regard to how India manages the rise of China. Even if it could be argued that Pakistan represents a more immediate threat to India, the combination of the growing power gap between India and China in favour of the latter, China's increased footprint and more assertive policies in India's traditional sphere of influence, and China's geographic proximity to India make China India's greatest strategic challenge.[15] In the first years after the end of the Cold War, India–China relations were surely characterised by engagement and a more pragmatic approach,[16] but the Indian debate on China soon became more centred on the challenges.[17] In the next section, we present the framework of analysis chosen to assist us in shedding light on New Delhi's response to China's rise.

Framework of analysis

Indian foreign policy scholar Rajesh Rajagopalan argued in a recent Carnegie Paper that: "Nonalignment is not a feasible option for countries that face significant security threats that cannot be countered by internal balancing alone. When internal balancing is insufficient, external balancing becomes necessary."[18] Raja gopalan furthermore states that India's non-alignment policy has been based on a rigid ideological basis and has hampered India's ability to respond to changes in the international security environment.[19] India has in recent years moved away from its previous non-aligned stance. Mohan Malik argued about ten years ago that India, in order to handle the challenge from China, must change its approach from non-alignment to multialignment, engaging major powers and multilateral forums in a wider web of